

Chapter 6

Rise of Asia, Geopolitical Shifts and Higher Education



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6.1 Introduction

Over the past three decades, systems of higher education around the world have undergone major changes. The ways in which higher education institutions (HEIs) are now governed have been radically transformed. The role of the state in funding higher education has become diminished, with non-public sources, including student tuition, becoming dominant. The core principles of the New Public Management (NPM) have redefined the ways in which academic work is now organized and coordinated, with new regimes of accountability. The values of the market have now begun to define approaches to teaching and learning, as well as the research themes that are given priority. The idea of education for its own sake has been marginalised, as its commercial outcomes are given precedence. At the same time, the number of students attending HEIs has grown rapidly and has more than doubled since the beginning of this century. This has transformed the demographic landscape of campuses, making diversity ubiquitous, giving rise to a new politics of difference that HEIs can no longer ignore. Nor can they overlook the growing backlash against equity initiatives.

These changes are historic, and have seemingly become entrenched in our imagination regarding the purposes and governance of higher education. Many critical scholars have attempted to understand this historical transformation, pointing to such factors as the emergence of Knowledge capitalism (Peters, 2013), the changing nature of work and labour relations (Brown & Lauder, 2016), and more broadly the impact of global processes and technological innovations. In this paper, I want to

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suggest that, along with these factors, the economic and political rise of Asia has also played a highly consequential role in reshaping the global architecture of higher education over the past three decades. I want to show how the rise of Asia, and the geopolitical shifts to which it has given rise, has affected the ways in which systems of higher education are now constituted, both within Asia and elsewhere, not only through policies of internationalization but also through the ways in which knowledge is now created, transmitted and utilized both within and across national borders.

6.2 Understanding Geopolitics

To appreciate how the economic and political rise of Asia has transformed the geopolitics of the world, and how HEIs are embedded within the dynamics of geopolitical shifts, it is important to begin with the idea of geopolitics. Dodds (2019) has argued that geopolitics is a slippery and highly contested concept: it refers both to a set of practices and institutional arrangements as well as various discursive constructions. At its core however is the premise that geography plays an important role not only in determining the great power politics of international relations but also in shaping the conduct of citizens, corporations, international bodies, social movements, governments, as well as institutions.

The idea of geopolitics thus suggests that the connections between place, the state and politics are affected by geographical arrangements, such as boundaries, coalitions, spatial networks, natural resources, and mobilities. These arrangements have the potential to redefine the ways in which political power is exercised, enforced or undermined at both global and local levels. According to Dodds (2019), any attempt to understand geopolitics involves three basic concerns: how questions of influence and power are shaped by spatial considerations; how geographical frames are helpful in making sense of global changes; and how this understanding can provide insights into the future behaviours of states, and their likely impact on individuals and institutions.

Traditionally, these concerns have been addressed through a realist lens (Dalby, 2013). The realist approach to geopolitics assumes that the relations between nation-states are largely anarchical, since there is no world government capable of restricting their actions. Hence, self-interest often drives the exercise of power in international relations, with nation-states as primary actors. The core function of nation-states is to provide security, and protect the domestic space and its citizens from the threat of the chaotic international. In this way, realism presupposes a binary between the *inside* (domestic, state) and the *outside* (chaotic, international). It also assumes the relationship between states to be inherently asymmetrical. It characterizes a stable global political space to be one in which chaos and anarchy is brought under a degree of control, either through various forms of strategic agreements between nations or through the dominance of some nations over others.

The critics of this approach (for example, Sharp, 2009) argue that the realist understanding of geopolitics over-states the extent of conflict and competition, and that the interstate system displays equally a capacity to collaborate, negotiate international law and work through intergovernmental bodies such as the European Union. Without denying the importance of nation-states, they insist moreover that nation-states are not the only actors in the configuration of geopolitics. The critical reading of geopolitics refuses to see the world *as it supposedly is*, but highlights instead the need to examine the relationship between geography and politics as ideologically constructed, ‘imbued with social and cultural meaning’ (Dodds, 2019, p. 34). It regards the relationship between place and politics as always contingent, complex and contextually determined. The critical approach also recognizes, in a manner that realism does not, “the everyday experiences of people and the strategies they have to adopt in order to cope with the geo-political and geo-economic processes as fundamentally varied” (p. 36), subject to interpretations of the dynamic shifts in international relations.

From this critical perspective, we might ask how geopolitical shifts have historically affected the ways in which systems of higher education are organized and changed. We might begin by noting that, before the Second World War, the spatial politics of colonialism largely created and fashioned the modern systems of higher education, as well as the relationship between them. The colonial powers, such as Britain and France, thus forged the character of HEIs in the lands they occupied. These HEIs operated within the registers of the geopolitical imagination of the colonizers. The colonial curriculum and pedagogic approaches were designed mostly to serve the empires, producing subjects that were loyal to their interests. Conversely, HEIs in Europe created and provided students knowledge of the colonialized world that was invariably articulated in Orientalist terms (Said, 1983).

As various colonies began to gain political independence after the Second World War, the geopolitics of the world shifted markedly. Yet most of the colonial arrangements remained persistent, despite attempts to cultivate new nationalist forms (Fanon, 1967). This persistence was partly due to the failure of the decolonized states to imagine new ways of thinking about the nature of knowledge and the role of their own HEIs played in creating and transmitting it. The lack of resources also led them to turn to the economically developed countries, their former colonizers, for aid and development assistance to expand their systems of higher education, in an effort to create a knowledge and skills base necessary to realize their nationalist aspirations.

The developed nations in turn often portrayed foreign aid as their moral responsibility. Strategically however foreign aid was always a way of extending their political influence and commercial interests internationally. Additionally, this ideology of ‘developmentalism’ (Escobar, 1995) played an important role in the machinations of the Cold War, with higher education becoming aligned to the competing geopolitical interests. Both Soviet Union and the United States, for example, sought to extend their geopolitical influence through scholarship programs offered to students in the developing countries, supposedly to prepare them to meet the requirements of national economic development (De Wit & Merks, 2012).

Since the end of the Cold War, this understanding of development persists to an extent, but is now tied to a view of geopolitics that has increasingly been shaped by modes of thinking associated with ideologies of free markets and liberal democracy (Roberts et al., 2003). The neoliberal understanding of globalization has encouraged a new kind of political imagination that does not quite abandon the ideas of international cooperation and development assistance, but augments them with perceptions of inter-state relations couched in commercial terms (Steger, 2017). This imaginary highlights the benefits that can be derived from a global interconnected market economy. It is underpinned by organizational reforms such as globally-stretched production, outsourcing, intercompany business, strategic alliances, clustering and diversification and technological innovations especially in the areas of information, communication and transport. It promotes the formation of transnational networks to boost the production and distribution of goods and services, leading to the expansion of the movement of capital, goods, services and people, and the rapid development of high information technologies, telecommunication networks and intellectual capital (Rizvi & Lingard, 2010).

Over the past three decades, these market ideologies have arguably become hegemonic, influencing almost all areas of human activity, including higher education. With the crisis of socialism on a global scale, there has been little competition to these ideologies. At the same time, intergovernmental organizations, global corporations and other non-state actors have become highly influential. Around the turn of the century, the World Trade Organization, for example, negotiated rules to govern patterns of international trade, in goods and services alike (Robertson et al., 2002), in an attempt to embed competition in most spheres of life. The World Bank has become highly effective in persuading nation-states to adopt policies consistent with neoliberal precepts. Global corporations are no longer reluctant to steer national policies as basic conditions under which foreign direct investments are made (Dicken, 2007). Non-state actors such as foundations and think tanks are now major carriers in the global circulation of neoliberal sentiments. These shifts have reconstituted the geopolitical space within which the nation-states now relate to each other, contributing to massive changes in almost all areas of social and economic relations in every region of the world.

6.3 Asia Rising

Nowhere has the impact of these changes been more profound than in Asia. Arguably, countries of East and Southeast Asia have been the major beneficiaries of the processes of economic globalization. In recent decades, the rates of economic growth in Asia have been historically unprecedented. Since early 1990s, the growth rates in Asia have, for example, averaged over 5.5% per year in per capita terms (Khanna, 2019), despite blips such as the Asian and Global Financial crises in 1997 and 2008 respectively. Asia has become the largest manufacturer in the world, with its global output growing from 29% in 1990 to 45% in 2009, and now over 50%. Its

share of the global economy in purchasing power parity terms rose from 21% in 2008 to 38% in 2014 (Pieterse, 2018). Asia is now also the world's largest consumer market. Seven of the top ten countries in terms of foreign reserve come from Asia, with Hong Kong, Tokyo, Singapore, Shanghai, and Mumbai becoming key international financial centres. Asia is now also the net capital exporter while remaining the largest recipient of foreign investment.

The drivers of the rapid economic growth in Asia, the quality of this growth, and its sustainability have been widely debated, as indeed has been the significance of these changes in reshaping geopolitics, from a wide variety of ideological perspectives. Asia's economic success, it has been argued, lies in the fact that most that Asian countries are sites of cheaper labour, as well as a disciplined and largely compliant workforce, borne out of their civilizational traditions (Jacques, 2009). It is also suggested that Asian countries have benefitted greatly from the preparedness to welcome foreign direct investment under conditions that have often been modified to suit the interests of global capitalism (Dicken, 2007). Many of these conditions are associated with structural adjustment programs, which include the demand to reduce the role of the state in global trade, permitting easier flows of capital, goods and people across national borders. Throughout Asia, Special Economic Zones have facilitated production processes under terms that favour global capital. In his defence of economic globalization, Bhagwati (2007) has argued the economic rise of Asia could not have been possible without market-friendly policies that resulted in radical changes in the role of the state in economic exchange. In this way, the developmental states in Asia, especially the so-called 'Asia Tigers', anticipated the market.

Yet these policies have not benefitted everyone in Asia. As Pieterse (2018) has argued, while the centre of global economic activity has shifted rapidly towards Asia in quantitative terms, serious questions need to be asked about the quality of economic growth in Asia. Also important are the questions as to whether this growth is sustainable, broad-based, inclusive and contributes sufficiently to the eradication of poverty. Pieterse (2018, p. 62) maintains that, "Asia is rising but Asian wellbeing is not. The quality and quantity of growth are out of synch. The high and rising Gini index in most Asian countries signal a growth path short of social development that is not sustainable." There are similarly questions about the sustainability of China's economic model, in particular, which is based on the assumptions of continuing economic size and export volume concentrated heavily on the US consumer market. China's environmental problems may also be reaching a stage where they could constrain its growth rates, upon which the Chinese state's political legitimacy is clearly based.

Despite these doubts about the nature and sustainability of the economic rise of Asia, what is beyond doubt is that celebratory discourses of 'Asia Rising' and the 'Asian Century' have now become common, both within Asia and elsewhere. For example, in his recent book, Khanna (2019) insists that the 'global future is Asian'. He argues that just as 'in the 19th century, the world was Europeanised. In the 20th century, it was Americanised. Now, in the 21st century, the world is being Asianised' (p. 1). Such discourses have led many scholars to rethink the nature of

contemporary geopolitics, with widely differing analytical conclusions and political suggestions.

According to Jacques (2009), for example, the Asian century will be led by China. The dynamism of the Chinese economy and its civilizational ambitions are such that China will herald ‘the end of the western world and the birth of a new global order’ (p. 2). China’s rapidly increasing economic strength and prowess will enable it to expand its clout in world affairs, resulting in a shift of power from the West to the East. In this way, Jacques insists that China’s rise is not only economic, but also political and cultural, with the potential to transform the geopolitics of the world, through such initiative as the Belt and Road (Vitcheck, 2019).

Mahbubani’s (2020) account of the global rise of China is in many ways similar, but focuses instead on the geopolitical contest between China and the US. He argues that for the foreseeable future, China and the US will remain world powers without any serious rivals, and will look at each other with growing suspicion. He suggests however that China may already be winning this geopolitical contest, and national governments around the world will need to consider how they position themselves in it. Success in the new geopolitical order will require managing the contested space between China and the US.

In contrast with the China-centric analyses of both Jacques and Mahbubani, Khanna (2019) suggests that the rise of Asia is a geopolitical phenomenon that is far greater than just China: it involves a new Asian system that is ‘multi-civilizational’, linking the five billion people on the Asian continent through trade, finance, infrastructure, and diplomatic networks that together represent 40 % of global GDP, and is growing rapidly. China has clearly taken a lead through its various policy initiatives, but Khanna insists, it will not lead alone. Rather, “Asia is rapidly returning to the centuries-old patterns of commerce, conflict, and cultural exchange that thrived long before European colonialism and American dominance” (Khanna, 2019, p. 2). While China is clearly a major player in this emerging Asian system, and has pursued aggressive foreign policies in the region, it is misleading, Khanna argues, to assume that it will dominate the rest of Asia, with little resistance from its neighbours.

Another perspective on the rise of Asia rejects the assumption that implies an inevitable decline of the Western values and practices. It suggests that through the histories of colonialism and neoliberal globalization, the values of capitalism and market economy have already become embedded in the political mainstream of most Asian countries (Delanty, 2006). Even China has endorsed an idea of democracy, even if it is assumed to have ‘Chinese characteristics’ (Harvey, 2005). Many of the neoliberal economic ideas have also been embraced by China, even as its understanding of the markets are couched to favour its authoritarian system of government. China’s approach to the markets is thus heavily regulated and controlled by its state institutions, including higher education. The so-called ‘Asian values’, this perspective suggests, are not entirely incompatible with the fundamentals in the Western value system. While it is true that the rise of Asia will lead to the redistribution of power and resources, this need not imply the fundamental splitting of the world community. Rather, the rise of Asia may ideally result in growing levels of intercultural exchange, hybridization of cultures and cultural creativity.

6.4 Global Markets in Higher Education

The discussion in the previous section indicates that there is no general agreement about the economic and political rise of Asia: how it is transforming the geopolitics of the world, and what implications this transformation has for the development of policy, at both national and institutional levels. Within Asia, economic growth has clearly transformed Asian societies. Its institutions, including systems of higher education, have expanded rapidly, with spectacular rise in gross enrolment rates (GER) (UIS, 2014). As Asian countries are increasingly integrated within the global economy, they have taken advantage of the global flows of capital and the globally distributed modes of production. This has created a strong middle class, which widely perceives higher levels of education to be a good investment in protecting and extending economic gains and social status. To meet the growing demand, a large number of new universities have emerged, while the competition for places in the region's older HEIs has intensified.

At the same time, governments throughout Asia have allocated large sums of public money to higher education, allowed greater private investment in the development of new universities and programs, and more importantly encouraged the public to view higher education as an investment in human capital, which will bring good returns to both individuals and the nation. A strong rhetoric has emerged that views higher education as necessary to meet the requirements of the globalizing economy. Effective participation in this economy, it is assumed, demands a steady supply of human resources with knowledge and skills to carry out the complex tasks inherent within the operations of the global supply chains.

In this way, in Asia as elsewhere, the expansion of higher education is considered necessary to participate in the global economy and hence realize the goals of national economic development (Slaughter & Rhoades, 2009). In line with this thinking, Asian systems of higher education have worked hard towards the renewal and reform of their policies, programs and practices, not only to bring about system efficiency but also ensure greater relevance and effectiveness. HEIs in Asia have, for example, sought to align their curriculum to the shifting requirements of the global labor market, as well as the changing national priorities. Furthermore, a strong discourse of quality improvement can be found throughout Asia, with a desire to realize the world's best practices, and to 'catch up' with the West's leading universities.

Systems of higher education beyond Asia are, of course, acutely aware of these changes in most parts of Asia. The response to this awareness in 'Western' countries has come in two contrasting ways. On the one hand, there is a great deal of admiration for what Asia has been able to achieve in a relatively short period of time (see for example, Henry Report, 2012). On the other hand, Western perceptions of the rise of Asia, and Asian systems of higher education, are located within a language of anxiety, with an assumption that the rise of the 'new East' is a 'powerfully disruptive force' that is likely to have 'unexpected economic, political, and social outcomes' (Simpfendorfer, 2014, p. 9).

At the same time, the rise of Asia is viewed by the ‘developed’ systems of higher education as an opportunity. In most western countries, HEIs have hence developed policies and programs of internationalization that invariably refer to the challenges and opportunities associated with of a globally interconnected world. They thus summon multiple and shifting social, political, cultural and economic rationales of international higher education (Knight, 2004). The recent discourses of international higher education pay particular attention to the rise of an Asian middle class, financially capable of purchasing education in a global market. According to Kharas (2017), globally, there were about 3.2 billion people in the middle class at the end of 2016, with an overwhelming majority of new entrants into the middle class living in Asia, with the capacity to pay for international higher education, as well as the costs of living abroad.

These numbers alone however do not fully reveal what being middle class in Asia means *qualitatively*, in aspirational terms of life styles, life chances and life plans. An education abroad ranks very highly among the Asian middle class, as a presumed source of capital accumulation. Not only is it assumed to improve life chances but it is also treated as a marker of social status and prestige (Ong, 2006). This is evident in the fact that throughout Asia the number of elite international schools has grown rapidly, claiming to provide students a good preparation for education in a western country. These colonial perceptions of western higher education are particularly common among Asia’s middle class (Kenway et al., 2017). They have given rise to a large industry that can be found in the capital cities of Asia to broker student mobility from a local elite school to a university in the West.

Significantly moreover, these perceptions have also become part of the strategic calculations of HEIs in countries like Australia, the UK, Canada and the United States, as they consider the commercial potential of higher education, within the context of declining public funds they are now allocated. There has thus been a shift from an older ‘developmentalist’ rationales for internationalization, which stressed the role of higher education in working towards modernization, social and cultural development, capacity-building, and in promoting international understanding and intercultural relations, to a view of international education now embedded within a broader market rationality (Rizvi, 2020). At the institutional level, this rationality is concerned with revenue generation, building institutional profile and reputation, diversifying the campus, and, in relation to curriculum, developing human resources for a globalizing economy.

Increasingly, higher education is now viewed as an export industry in which universities compete for students, funds and status. As an industry, it is now governed through an administrative technology, with rules of operation based on an expertise that incorporates knowledge of market segments and specificities, as well as a symbolic language about the distinctive benefits of internationalization. There are also targeted advertising programs conducted not only through the media, and through educational expos and market-oriented conferences. While other aspects of internationalization, such as teaching and learning, are not entirely discounted, market concerns disproportionately attract the attention of senior HEI administrators, as they struggle to balance their budgets. The success of HEIs is now often measured

in terms of the number of fee-paying international students they are able to recruit. This is what various global ranking systems measure and governments celebrate.

This market perspective on internationalization has transformed the relationship between the state and higher education more generally. A commitment to public values has been ‘crowded out’ (Sandel, 2012). With international student tuition becoming a major source of income, governments no longer feel inclined to provide HEIs the public funds they need. In Australia, for example, the success that its HEIs have had in recruiting full fee-paying international students in large numbers has emboldened the Australian governments to promote other market-oriented policies. Practices of ‘endogenous privatization’ (Ball, 2012) appear to have become a permanent feature of public higher education in most Western countries. More generally, NPM ideas, techniques and practices borrowed from the corporate sector are widely imported in an effort to make public HEIs more business-like.

A highly innovative system of recruitment has been cultivated in the use of local agents throughout Asia, who are often the first point of contact between potential students and a university abroad. Also established is a vast array of transnational programs. In the image of other service industries, various franchise arrangements are also developed, with varying degrees of success (McBurnie & Ziguras, 2006). In promoting such ‘export’ practices, governments play a major role in helping HEIs to craft agreements to provide a range of educational services beyond their national border. To extend their market reach, HEIs in Western countries also enter into complex articulation and twinning arrangements with educational providers in Asia to ensure a steady flow of students to their home campuses. The global architecture of higher education has thus been transformed.

6.5 Competition and Collaboration

This architecture embodies a culture of competition across HEIs and national systems, involving commercial arrangements regarding trade in educational services (Marginson, 2006). To manage and regulate competition, attempts have been made to develop a set of rules for the global trade in education. In the early 2000s, these efforts were led by international organisations, such as the World Trade Organization (WTO). Its General Agreement on Trade in Services (GATS) is a multilateral agreement, which encourages WTO members to accept voluntary liberalisation of trade in services. Although GATS does not have strong compliance mechanisms, its ideological import cannot be overlooked. It views higher education as a commodity, subject to commercial competition in much the same way as other goods and services. It thus helps to implant and legitimize the neoliberal shifts in higher education. As Collins (2007, p. 283) has noted: “language and text can create, shift, or maintain ideologies. In the case of GATS, the ideology reflects a new imperialism where more powerful countries retain developing countries as markets in which they continue to rule intellectually”.

The Western systems of higher education are understandably sensitive to such perceptions, so have sought to forge a policy discourse that not only promotes competition for the globally mobile students, but also invokes opportunities in interstate collaboration, particularly in the area of research (Rizvi & Nadarajah, 2019). There is of course nothing new about transnational research collaborations in higher education. Academies have always cooperated with scholars from abroad to exchange information and collaborate in the production of new knowledge. In the 1950s, however, scholarly exchange acquired a new purpose, of serving the strategic interests of the developed countries within the broader politics of the Cold War. Over the past three decades, however, the rationales for forging transnational research collaborations across national boundaries have expanded greatly, beyond the academic interests of individual researchers. For individual researchers, collaborations continue to represent an opportunity to access expertise, equipment, datasets and other resources that may not be available within the nations, enabling them to tap into global networks. Collaborations enable scholars to stay in touch with knowledge being developed in other parts of the world, and align their work with high status institutions and research teams, resulting in the likelihood of publishing their research in high impact journals. For institutions of higher education, however, broader considerations are at play, including the ability to meet the infrastructure needs of staff, especially in capital-intensive fields, to support entry into new fields of research, benchmark the performance of staff, and help determine what is needed to enhance global reputation.

National governments have additional reasons for advocating transnational research collaborations, often linked to the objectives of trade and modern public diplomacy. In recent decades, governments have recognized that research is a globally interconnected endeavour. They thus view research collaborations as a significant form of institutional and people-to-people connectivity between countries. It is suggested, for example, that when “researchers work together across national boundaries, they do not only contribute to the global production of knowledge; they also play a part in sustaining a culture of cooperation that contributes to more harmonious international relations” (Ang et al., 2015, p. 43). In this way, intercultural, commercial, strategic and diplomatic interests of nations are fused together in a new complex combination of rationales for promoting research collaborations.

The language of collaborations highlights what Yonchai Benkler (2006) refers to ‘the wealth of networks’. Benkler claims that nation-states are no longer the only source of knowledge creation and economic productivity, but that it is the transnational networks that have the potential to generate commercially useful knowledge. With the radical changes in information technologies, Benkler insists, we now stand at a key moment of transition. Globalization, he suggests, implies a new mode of social production that is reshaping markets, while at the same time creating new opportunities to enhance individual freedom, cultural diversity, political discourse, and justice. This line of thinking was first proposed two decades ago by Castells (1996), who argued that the main mode of social organization in politics, economy and civil society is shifting from relatively stable hierarchy, represented by the nation-states, to a more fluid networked form. It has now become mainstreamed.

Systems of higher education around the world have increasingly embraced this thinking to encourage and reward transnational research projects, especially if they produce commercial outcomes. They highlight the emergence of a globally distributive system of knowledge development and dissemination that needs to be regularised through on-going and symmetrical transnational links. They promote the need to create research networks, as a way of sharing income, resources and effort. Early examples of such networks included *Universitas 21* and Global Universities Network (GUN), which have now lost their appeal, replaced by new less formal modalities of transnational collaborations. These initiatives are moreover supported by intergovernmental organizations. The OECD (2020), for example, hosts and coordinates a Research Collaborative of governments, research institutions and international finance institutions, the goal of which is “to partner and share best available data, expertise and information to advance policy-relevant research in a comprehensive and timely manner” (OECD, 2020, p. 1). The European Union has developed a robust regional approach to research collaboration through the creation of its European Research Area that seeks to integrate the scientific resources of the European Union.

However, the European approach to research collaboration is not confined to Europe. Recognising the rapid growth of research productivity in many parts of Asia, it now advocates cooperative links with Asian HEIs. The regular meetings of the Asia-Europe Meeting (ASEM), for example, stimulate dialogues about the cooperation process, addressing such issues as environment, energy, climate change, the green economy, and higher education (Lee & Healy, 2006). A program called ‘EURAXESS-ASEAN’, for example, links researchers in Southeast Asia with Europe, through sharing of information on research funding, research careers and collaboration opportunities, supporting projects of mutual interest (Rizvi, 2018).

As HEIs in East Asia become major global players in STEM research, leading universities the West, including those in the United States, have attempted to capitalize on opportunities inherent in the attempts by Asian countries to become major global players in research and development. Few countries have been as aggressive in developing strategic links with Asian systems of higher education as Australia. In 2012, a major report in Australia, argued that since twenty-first century is likely to be an ‘Asian century’, Australian people and institutions had to recognize the implications of this fact for their future prosperity. It suggested that: “The Asian Century is an Australian opportunity. As the global centre of gravity shifts to our region, the tyranny of distance is being replaced by the prospects of proximity” (Henry Report, 2012, p. 1).

The Australian government has therefore invested heavily in programs such as the Australia-India Strategic Research Fund (AISRF) and the Australia China Science and Research Fund (ACSRF), designed to maintain and strengthen “research relationships with high performing nations that enhance our performance” and collaborate with Asian countries that “have complementary research priorities and challenges” (Barlow, 2014, p. 13). More broadly, the Australian government’s National Strategy for International Education 2025 aims “to strengthen partnerships at home and abroad, enhance student and faculty mobility, and position Australian

education institutions to compete globally by promoting excellence and embracing opportunities to expand international education” (p. 1). Its industry-oriented National Innovation and Science Agenda incorporates strategies that also aim to facilitate increased international research collaboration and partnerships with industry.

6.6 Covid-19, Geopolitical Tensions and Higher Education

Towards the end of 2019, it might have been possible to provide a relatively settled portrayal of the global architecture of higher education. It might have been argued, for example, the ideas of globalization and market economy had transformed the geopolitics of the world, and that this fact could no longer be overlooked by the policies and practices of HEIs, even if higher education also served a range of other nationally-specific purposes, such as political socialization. The continuing growth in the number of globally mobile students and scholars might have been taken for granted, making HEIs in Western countries in particular heavily reliant on the income generated from student tuition, especially from students recruited from an economically rising middle class in Asia. Indeed, the assumptions regarding the economic and political rise of Asia were embedded within the planning processes and operational practices of internationalization of higher education, resting upon a particular understanding of the geopolitical shifts that had taken place since the end of the Cold War. These developments did not quite abandon the ethical and cultural purposes of higher education, but couched them within a broader commercial logic. Even the objectives of research collaborations were located within a global system based on the assumptions of competition and strategic goals of public diplomacy.

Of course many of these developments were never universally embraced. Early in 2020, however, COVID-19 further unsettled many of these assumptions upon which they are based, disrupting many aspects of HEIs in western countries in particular, most notably how they should now to be funded; how students should be taught; and how buildings should be re-configured to ensure the safety of students, staff, and administrators. The pandemic has put severe financial strains on most HEIs, with international student markets no longer able to rescue them. It is now clear many HEIs in countries such as the UK and Australia had become excessively dependent on this source of income, particularly the students from the growing Asian middle class. When the pandemic hit, many of these students returned home, and some are unlikely to resume their studies internationally. Many HEIs are therefore no longer able to rely on the growth projections that they had made in the time of plenty to support their capital and human resources plans, as well as new initiatives. With government revenues also stretched, HEIs can also no longer expect public largesse to ensure their sustainability, let alone expand. Decline appears highly likely within the context of uncertainties.

Exactly how HEIs might manage decline remains to be seen, even if they have displayed remarkable capacity to adapt their curriculum and pedagogic practices to

the changing conditions. Both staff and students have, for example, embraced technological tools of teaching and learning at a speed that is truly extraordinary. Regrettably however, while the pandemic has created a space for innovation, this space has not been used widely to re-think online pedagogy, radically overhaul the nature of student engagement and student-teacher relations, reimagine the processes of knowledge ownership, creation, distribution and utilization, and re-conceptualize the idea of learning itself (Rizvi, 2020). HEIs have shown little evidence of realizing the enormous potential of the new technological tools of pedagogy, for establishing robust learning communities across national, cultural and political differences, for remaining Asia's contribution to the world.

Much of the debate within the systems of higher education that recruit large number of Asian students has revolved around questions of how to 'recover' the financial losses caused by Covid-19. This language of recovery focuses on arresting the decline in student numbers, expanding and diversifying the source countries, rethinking the technologies of student recruitment, meeting the needs of the returning student consumer, and putting pressure on the government to change the student visa conditions to make it easier for international students to return. What is overlooked is the possibility that the current business model of international education, based on neoliberal assumptions, may no longer be apt within the context of the geopolitics that has potentially been transformed by the Covid crisis. The pandemic has arguably revealed some of the deeper contradictions that underlie the neoliberal imaginary of globalization, as well as the current policies and practices of internationalization in higher education.

Most notably, the current narratives of internationalization of higher education define the dynamics and possibilities of global mobility of students, in terms that privilege the commercial, above the ethical and political. And yet the assumptions regarding the global mobility of students and scholars have been deeply unsettled by the pandemic. They have also highlighted the need to rethink the nature of the relationship between the public and private, the responsibilities of governments to support HEIs. They encourage transnational research collaborations between western and the rising Asias systems of higher education, but such collaborations are either exploitive of non-western traditions or else reproduce asymmetrical patterns of power. The growing geopolitical tensions, especially those involving China, are moreover shifting the grounds upon which the neoliberal imaginary of globalization is based and celebrated. The disputes over the origins of Covid-19, technology transfer, human rights and Hong Kong have led to international students from China in particular feeling less welcome and secure. They have also revealed further a more politically assertive China on the global stage, in a diverse range of activities including the production, dissemination and utilization of knowledge.

These tensions have potentially transformed the geopolitics of the world, and cannot be overlooked by systems of higher education everywhere. What needs to be realized is that the emerging geopolitics is characterised by multiple ties and interactions linking people and institutions across the borders of nation-states, defined by systems that demand reciprocity and mutual benefit. Anglo-American countries are no longer able to define the terms of economic, political and cultural exchange

unchallenged. In more recent years, academic cooperation across the emerging economies has been growing, challenging the hegemony of the Anglo-American view of internationalization of higher education. Within the emerging systems, new asymmetries of power are emerging, with China, for example, using higher education as an instrument of global influence (King, 2013). While HEIs in the English-speaking world continue to dominate, other centres of knowledge production, particularly in Asia, are emerging. On the world stage, many of these systems regard their cultural and epistemic heritage as equally vital, if not superior. If this is so then a new imaginary of globalization must consider the new possibilities of collaboration and networking among individuals and institutions dealing with knowledge production and dissemination, beyond the commercial.

The post-pandemic dynamics of higher education must challenge the asymmetrical power relations that have resulted in unidirectional flows of students, money and ideas—from the rest to the West. The changing geopolitics of the world thus demands new ways of thinking about internationalization of higher education, especially against a growing assertion of knowledge traditions other than those associated with colonial modernity (Stein, 2017) and western rationalism (Connell, 2007). At the same time, developments in technology have eroded to a considerable extent the distinction between knowledge production and dissemination and have given rise to new pedagogic possibilities of the ubiquitous social media and communication technologies. This has given rise to major shifts in youth cultures accompanied by new practices of global networking, thus transforming the ways in which internationalization of higher education might now be envisaged.

These and other developments have highlighted the importance of transnational collaborations in higher education, but not in terms that are predicated on the logic of educational markets. They suggest the possibilities of symmetrical transnational links inherent in the emerging distributive systems of knowledge development and dissemination. They indicate the need to create transnational bilateral and multilateral teaching and research networks among universities and industries, as a way of developing new modes of sharing income, resources and effort. This emphasis on transnational collaborations implies rethinking the nature and scope of higher education itself. This new perspective on internationalization demands re-examining the traditional curriculum, challenged by the claims of ‘other’ knowledge traditions, developing new pedagogies that are more responsive to recent innovations in social media and the ubiquitous technologies of communication. The pandemic and the geopolitical tensions that they have revealed may take a long time to be resolved, but they have provided us, as Arundhoti Roy (2020) has noted, with a new portal for imagining a new geopolitics of the world and of higher education.

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